

HSE TOOLBOX TALK

DROPPED OBJECT PREVENTION ZONES

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

Tools, materials and equipment used aloft can create fatal energy when dropped. Remove unnecessary items, secure tools and parts at source, protect edges with toe boards or screening, and calculate and physically barricade the potential drop zone. A hard hat does not replace controls at the source.

KEY HAZARDS

1



OVERHEAD WORK

2



OPEN EDGE

3



UNCONTROLLED ENTRY

4



DROPPED TOOL

5



SUSPENDED LOAD

6



WIND

7



TETHER FAILURE

8



DEFLECTED OBJECT

CRITICAL VALUES TO VERIFY IN THE FIELD

9 cm

Minimum toe-board height

0 people

People permitted in an active drop zone

100%

Tethering of small tools aloft



REMEMBER - SERNEM

S

Stop and think

E

Evaluate the risk

R

Remove or reduce

N

Never assume

E

Ensure protection

M

Monitor and communicate

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STANDARDS AND FIELD REQUIREMENTS

OSHA treats falling-object control as a combination of source restraint, edge protection and restricted access. The drop zone is not limited to the point directly below; deflection and bounce must also be considered.

OSHA 1926.501(c)

FALLING-OBJECT PROTECTION

Use appropriate toe boards, screens, guardrails, canopies or barricaded areas and require hard hats.

OSHA 1926.502(j)

TOE BOARDS AND SCREENS

Toe boards must be at least 9 cm high with limited openings; add higher panels or screening where needed.

OSHA 1926.451(h)

SCAFFOLD FALLING OBJECTS

Protect scaffold users and lower levels with toe boards, screening, canopies or barricades.

OSHA 1926.759(a)

STEEL-ERECTION ZONE

Keep unsecured material away from the work level and never drop it uncontrolled; coordinate simultaneous work above and below.

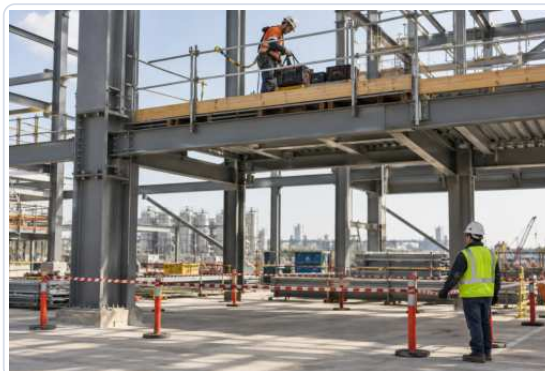
MINIMUM EVIDENCE BEFORE START

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Dropped-object risk assessment | ☐ Tool-tether register |
| ☐ Drop-zone layout | ☐ Barricade inspection |
| ☐ Simultaneous-work coordination | ☐ Shift briefing record |

SUPERVISOR DISCUSSION POINTS

- Where could this object bounce if dropped?
- What is the tool tether attached to?
- Who may remove the barricade?

SOURCE RESTRAINT AND BARRICADED DROP ZONE



Tethered tools - Toe board - Secured material - Barricade - Spotter - Communication

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CRITICAL CONTROL MEASURES (HIERARCHY OF CONTROLS)

1. REMOVE UNNECESSARY ITEMS

Take only the tools and materials required for the task aloft.

2. SECURE AT SOURCE

Use tool tethers, closed bags, secured parts and controlled material transfer.

3. PROTECT THE EDGE

Use toe boards, screening, panels or canopies to prevent objects reaching lower levels.

4. CLOSE THE DROP ZONE

Barricade for bounce and wind, and provide a spotter and communication.

CRITICAL WARNING



A hard hat alone does not make entry into a drop zone safe. Never cross the barricade while work continues above, and do not leave untethered tools in pockets or on guardrails.

SITE CHECKLIST (BEFORE STARTING WORK)

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Overhead work and area below identified | ☐ Unnecessary material removed |
| ☐ Tools secured with suitable tethers | ☐ Materials transferred in closed containers |
| ☐ Toe boards / screening adequate | ☐ Drop zone physically barricaded |
| ☐ No simultaneous work below | ☐ Wind and deflection assessed |
| ☐ Spotter and communication ready | |

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ATTENDANCE AND APPROVAL

Project / Site:

Date:

Presented by:

Work area:

No	Full Name	Company / Role	Signature
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			